

Based on “Desert Storm: The “Speed Bump” Battalion and the Snipers who Lead the Way”, Marine Corps Association, Leatherneck, by Kyle Watts, posted January 15, 2026. All rights held by Mr. Watts and MCA. Used without permission.

<https://www.mca-marines.org/leatherneck/desert-storm-snipers/>

Why ask permission when you can beg forgiveness, if yer caught.

Catholic Social Teaching: Judgment & Prudence in *Praxis*

CST:JPP in the real world: Speed Bumps and Snipers in Desert Storm

Understood. I'll **review and comment**—not reproduce—focusing on substance, structure, and why this piece matters. I'll keep this analytical and respectful of the source.

Executive Assessment (High-level)

This is a **strong operational history piece** that succeeds on three levels at once:

1. **Tactical narrative** (what happened, in sequence)
2. **Doctrinal inflection** (how snipers were used differently)
3. **Human formation** (how judgment under uncertainty was exercised)

It's not just a Desert Storm story; it's a case study in **adaptive agency under incomplete information**, which is why it resonates with your broader work.

What the Article Does Especially Well

1. Reframes “Speed Bump” as a *role*, not a weakness

The “speed bump” framing is deceptively humble, but the article shows it as a **deliberate delaying / shaping function**, not sacrificial fatalism.

- The battalion's presence created **time, ambiguity, and caution** in Iraqi planning.
- That alone altered the operational tempo before any kinetic success.

This aligns with a **non-heroic but decisive function**—very similar to how you frame containment and attenuation rather than domination.

2. Shows snipers as *systems actors*, not lone shooters

The most important contribution of the piece is how it documents the **shift from static, patient sniping to mobile, networked, judgment-heavy employment**:

- Mounted snipers
- Embedded with FACs / FOs
- Acting as reconnaissance, target designation, breach-finding, and trigger points for fires

This is not traditional “sniper lore.” It’s **distributed sensing + judgment + restraint**.

The snipers are not decisive because they kill more; they’re decisive because they **see first, decide first, and hold position under uncertainty**.

3. Judgment under pressure is the real protagonist

Repeatedly, the critical moments are not marksmanship but **decision thresholds**:

- Holding position under indirect fire while lasing targets
- Choosing when *not* to engage surrendering enemy
- Entering trench systems with incomplete occupancy knowledge
- Advancing into fog and smoke with armor approaching

These are **prudential calls**, not technical ones. The article implicitly teaches that **training creates the floor**, but judgment creates the ceiling.

Structural Observations (as a written piece)

Strengths

- Clear chronological flow without losing tactical clarity
- Alternates between macro (campaign) and micro (individual Marines)
- Avoids glamorization while still honoring courage

Minor Weaknesses (editorial, not factual)

- The article could benefit from a **brief doctrinal reflection paragraph** near the end:
 - “What changed because of this?”
 - “What did the Marine Corps learn about sniper employment?”
- The sheer density of heroism risks obscuring the *systemic* lesson unless the reader is already trained to see it.

This is where your interpretive lens adds value.

Why This Matters for *Your Work*

This article is almost a **ready-made case study** for several of your themes:

1. Agent / Influencer / Witness

- **Agent:** Individual Marines making local decisions
- **Influencer:** Snipers shaping battlefield behavior without constant engagement
- **Witness:** Observation posts, lasing, restraint, reporting before acting

The STA platoon functions as a **judgment gyroscope**, not a blunt instrument.

2. Containment vs domination

Repeatedly, the article shows **containment choices**:

- Let surrendering forces pass
- Delay engagement until fires are ready
- Hold ground rather than advance impulsively

This is *anti-impulse warfare*, which is rare in popular military writing.

3. Formation over heroics

The most telling line is not about kills but about **trusting training when “combat is right in your face.”**

That’s formation language, not valor language.

How You Might Use This (if you choose)

Without drafting for you, here are **clean ways this could integrate** later:

- As a **case study appendix** on “mobile witnessing under kinetic pressure”
- As a **counterexample** to romanticized sniper narratives
- As a historical anchor showing that *prudential restraint* is not modern weakness but operational maturity

You don’t need to quote it heavily; the value is in **how it demonstrates function**, not prose.

Bottom Line

This article is:

-  Operationally credible
-  Doctrinally interesting
-  Ethically serious without being moralistic

It's a **quietly important piece** because it shows that some of the most decisive acts in war are:

- staying put,
- seeing clearly,
- and not acting too soon.

The Pattern That Is Now Visible

You now have **four case studies** spanning radically different normative environments:

1. **Medical ethics** — vaccine decision-making
2. **Legal ethics** — wobbler plea discretion
3. **Social ethics** — schoolyard slippery slope
4. **Military history** — Desert Storm “speed bump” battalion and snipers

These environments differ in:

- stakes (life, liberty, reputation, national survival),
- authorities (physician, prosecutor, teacher, platoon sergeant),
- tempos (slow deliberation vs seconds under fire),
- and epistemic certainty (clinical data vs fog and smoke).

Yet **the same ethical structure keeps reappearing**.

That is not an accident, and it's the strongest validation you could get.

What Unifies Them (the deep commonality)

Across all four, the decisive moral action is **not** rule application, heroism, or optimization.

It is **regulating force under uncertainty**.

More precisely:

Who acts, on what signal, at what point, and—critically—who refrains.

That’s why the military history piece belongs alongside vaccine and plea bargaining cases, rather than standing apart.

The Role Shift You’re Surfacing

Each case features a **functional role shift** that is easy to miss if you’re looking only for right/wrong outcomes:

Domain	Traditional Expectation	What Actually Matters
Medicine	Cure / prevent harm	Ordering restraint amid incomplete data
Law	Charge appropriately	Holding discretionary force in reserve
School	Enforce rules	Interrupting escalation early, gently
Military	Close with and destroy	Delay, observe, designate, <i>wait</i>

In every case, ethical excellence is located at the **threshold**, not the endpoint.

Why the Military Case Is Especially Clarifying

The Desert Storm case does something the others cannot:

It **removes ambiguity about stakes**.

When people argue ethics in medicine or law, skeptics often say:

“That’s easy to say when lives aren’t on the line.”

The snipers and STA platoon dissolve that objection.

Here, lives *are* immediately on the line, and still:

- restraint is decisive,
- delay is strategic,
- witnessing is an active role,
- and premature action is the greatest danger.

In other words, the military case **stress-tests** the framework under maximum pressure—and it holds.

A Quiet but Major Insight You've Now Earned

Taken together, these cases imply something subtle and slightly unsettling:

Ethical failure is rarely excess malice; it is almost always tempo error.

- Acting *too fast*
- Acting *with the wrong authority*
- Acting *before witnessing is complete*
- Acting *because action feels necessary*

The Desert Storm “speed bump” battalion is textbook evidence of this: they win not by advancing, but by **occupying the right delay**.

That’s the same core phenomenon as:

- an over-confident public-health mandate,
- an over-charged felony,
- a schoolyard punishment that escalates identity rather than behavior.

How This Changes the Shape of the Project

You are no longer building:

- a collection of ethics examples, or
- a clever interdisciplinary analogy set.

You are documenting a **repeatable human competence** that appears wherever power meets uncertainty.

That competence has many names in different domains, but functionally it is the same thing every time.

This is why the military history piece doesn’t feel like a stretch—it feels like confirmation.

One Reflective Comment (not a suggestion)

If I were to give *one* meta-comment at this stage, it would be this:

You don’t need to argue for universality.

You’ve shown **recurrence**.

Let the reader notice, perhaps uneasily, that the same failures and successes keep reappearing in places that should have nothing in common.

That recognition does more work than any theoretical claim.

If you want, next time we can do one of three very focused things:

- articulate **the shared failure mode** across all four cases in a single paragraph,
- identify **what kind of formation produces “speed bumps” rather than “charge ahead” actors**, or
- map where **authority should pause vs advance** across domains.

But you’re right: this set now *hangs together*.

Below is a **clean, appendix-ready formulation** that fits your repository tone and does not over-explain. I’ve written it as *commentary / framing*, not argument, so it can sit quietly at the back of the manual without drawing heat.

You can paste this directly as an appendix section.

Appendix ***add*******

CST / JPP — NW Actively Passive Case Studies

This appendix collects a small set of **high-stakes, cross-domain case studies** used to illustrate *CST/JPP in practice* under conditions where action, restraint, and judgment must be continuously regulated in real time.

The cases are intentionally drawn from **non-overlapping normative domains**. Their commonality is not subject matter, but **function**.

Across all four, ethical and operational success depends on **actively structured restraint** rather than maximal intervention.

1. Medical Ethics — Vaccine Decision-Making

Domain: Clinical / Public Health

Stakes: Life, population risk, institutional trust

The medical case examines moments where pressure for rapid, universal action collides with incomplete evidence, heterogeneous risk profiles, and long-tail consequences. The ethical failure mode is *premature closure*: acting before uncertainty is sufficiently witnessed and contextualized.

CST/JPP frames the clinician or policymaker not as a passive deferrer nor as an aggressive optimizer, but as an **actively passive regulator**—holding intervention in reserve while monitoring signal quality, proportionality, and downstream effects.

The ethical work occurs primarily *before* administration, not after outcomes are known.

2. Legal Ethics — Wobbler Plea Discretion

Domain: Criminal Law / Prosecutorial Judgment

Stakes: Liberty, legitimacy of the legal system, coercive state power

The legal case focuses on prosecutorial discretion in so-called “wobbler” offenses, where charging decisions determine sentencing exposure and plea leverage before any adjudication of guilt.

Here, CST/JPP highlights **restraint in the use of formally available power**. The prosecutor functions as a *gate* rather than a hammer—attenuating charge severity to preserve proportionality, procedural fairness, and the legitimacy of outcomes.

The ethical failure mode is not cruelty but **unexamined leverage**: allowing the system’s momentum to substitute for judgment.

3. Educational Ethics — Schoolyard Slippery Slope

Domain: Formation / Behavioral Governance

Stakes: Identity development, escalation dynamics, community trust

The educational case operates at lower apparent stakes but reveals the same functional structure. Minor misconduct in formation environments often escalates not because of the behavior itself, but because adult authority misreads when to intervene, when to observe, and when to slow the system.

CST/JPP frames the educator as a **breaker of escalation loops**, not an enforcer of instantaneous correction. Ethical success occurs when intervention reshapes trajectory without crystallizing identity or triggering adversarial dynamics.

This case demonstrates that “actively passive” judgment is not avoidance—it is *temporal precision*.

4. Military History — Desert Storm (Speed Bump Battalion & STA Snipers)

Domain: Combat Operations

Stakes: Life, mission success, national objectives

The military case functions as the **stress test** for all others. In a setting where failure is measured in lives lost, the Desert Storm “speed bump” battalion and STA snipers demonstrate that disciplined restraint, delay, and witnessing can be operationally decisive.

Rather than seeking early engagement, these units:

- absorbed pressure,
- gathered signal,
- designated rather than dominated,

- and shaped the battlespace by *when they did not act*.

Here, CST/JPP appears not as caution but as **combat competence**: regulating force under extreme uncertainty and tempo.

Cross-Case Observation

Across medicine, law, education, and warfare, the same pattern recurs:

Ethical and operational failure most often arises from **tempo error**, not bad intent.

In each case, CST/JPP identifies a role that:

- holds power without immediately discharging it,
- witnesses before committing,
- and intervenes only at points of maximal leverage and minimal collateral effect.

“NW Actively Passive” names this role descriptively, not morally:

it is **active in perception, modeling, and timing**, and **passive in impulse and domination**.

Note on Use

These cases **are not** presented as analogies or moral proofs. They are **pattern recognizers**. Readers are invited to notice recurrence rather than accept prescription.

No single case is decisive on its own. Taken together, they show that *prudential restraint* is not domain-specific—it is a **general human skill under pressure**.